

Matisse

One of the most innovative and influential artists of the 20th century, and a pivotal figure in the development of modern art, Henri Matisse (1869–1954) is often referred to as the 'master of colour'. In 1905, he became leader of the short-lived Fauvist movement, using explosive colours and expressive brushwork. His diverse influences included Poussin, Manet, Cézanne, Gauguin, Van Gogh, Seurat, Signac, the Orientalists and the colours and shapes of the South of France, Spain, North Africa and Islamic art.

In 1906, he visited Algeria and Morocco, where the radiant light, exotic surroundings and Moorish architecture inspired him. After visiting Seville in 1911, he began spending time in Collioure, Paris and Nice. His mastery of colour enabled him to evoke feelings of happiness. He said: 'What I dream of is an art ... devoid of troubling or depressing subject matter ... which could be for every mental worker, for the businessman as well as the man of letters, for example, a soothing, calming influence on the mind, something like a good armchair which provides relaxation from physical fatigue.'



Matisse, *The Open Window*, 1911